

Cambridge are left-wingers," says Digvijay Singh, a Samata Party leader and former JNU students' union president. The politics of anti-establishment is one reason why both the BJP-affiliated Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP) and the CPI(M) student wing Students Federation of India (SFI) turned out to be better placement agencies than the Congress's National Students' Union of India (NSUI) and groomed the face of today's polity. Most of BJP's second-rung leaders today, such as Rajnath Singh, Jaitley, Ananth Kumar, Ravi Shankar Prasad and Venkaiah Naidu, have cut their teeth on student politics—some were also jailed during the Emergency. The Nav Nirman movement against the then Congress government in Gujarat became a young ABVP organiser Narendra Modi's "karam bhoomi". CPI(M)'s top duo, Prakash Karat and Sitaram Yechury, are former JNU presidents. Socialist leaders such as Lalu

Prasad Yadav, Nitish Kumar and Digvijay were inspired by the JP movement. "I recall how Jaiprakash Narain used to visit colleges and talk to students. He explained to us the meaning of democracy," says Yadav, a former Patna University students' president.

But now the age of idealism is over. Leaders do not have a 21st century cause to sell to the young—there is no mass movement against corruption or social inequities. "Parliament debates today are all about FERA (Foreign Exchange Regulation Act) and the Sensex. The poor no longer figure in our debates," says Digvijay. Along with new semantics is the death of old jargon like the ideological debate. With socialism in India reduced to just a motley collection of yesterday's leaders and communists propping up a pro-capitalist government at the Centre, there are few credible peddlers of anti-establishment currency left. Who will inspire the young and the idealistic today?

As far as Congress is concerned, the grooming field of leadership was the Indian Youth Congress (IYC). At the Congress session in Indore in 1971, Indira Gandhi had announced that IYC would take on the right wing parties with Priya Ranjan Dasmunshi as its second and also the only elected president. The youth wing peaked during 1976-1981 when Sanjay Gandhi stormed the nation with programmes such as slum demolitions, family planning, each-one-teach-one, each-one-plant-one-tree and anti-dowry campaigns. In a recent interview, Commerce Minister Kamal Nath recalled, "We were the Youth Congress. We had a very focused five-point programme." This firebrand group was the backbone of Indira's Congress in the '70s. Today, most of its leaders—Nath, Dasmunshi, Ambika Soni, Vayalar Ravi, Ghulam Nabi Azad, Mukul Wasnik and B.K. Hariprasad—play a key role in the government and the party. Who has the time to focus on

THE LOST GENERATION. THE POLITICAL LEADERS OF TODAY DO NOT HAVE A TWENTY-FIRST CENTURY CAUSE TO SELL TO THE YOUNG.

THE PAST & THE PRESENT: (L to R, front) BJYM President Thakkar, IYC chief Tanwar, DU President Amrita Bahri, NSUI President Nadeem Javed, JNU President Sandeep; (back) Modi, Karat, Jaitley, Dasmunshi, Nitish, Soni, Rajnath, Yechury and Yadav

